HONG KONG–SHENZHEN / AN EXPLORATORY STUDY

CROSS-BORDER LIVES

Everyday opportunities, adjustments and connections

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Research and presentation: Jamie Ko / Visual support: Bob / Field photographs supplied by Bob and Jamie

Hong Kong-centred exploratory study. People in field photographs are not identified as interviewees.

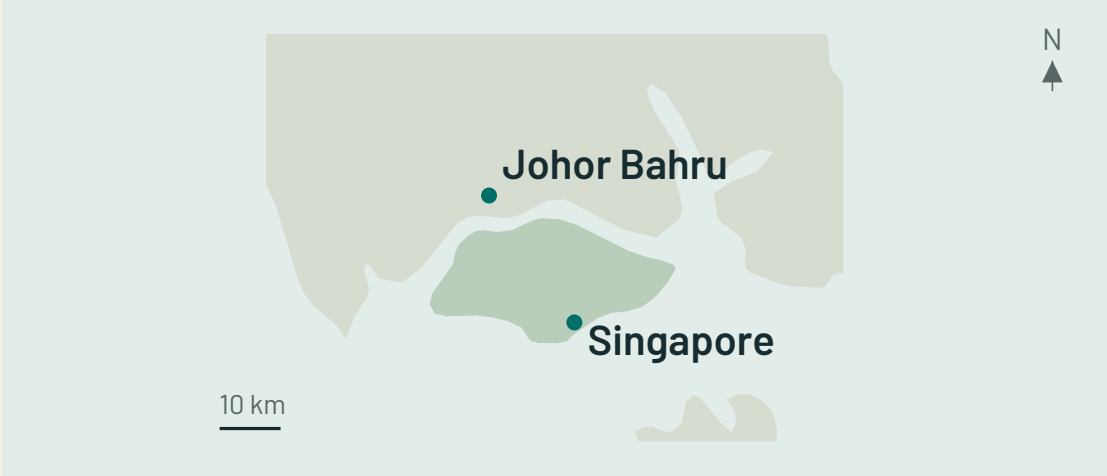
REGIONAL CONTEXT

Two city pairs; different institutional settings.



Hong Kong–Shenzhen

One country; different systems



Singapore–Johor

JS-SEZ in Johor / RTS is a separate rail link

MTI / EDB, JS-SEZ factsheet [1]; LTA / Malaysia MOT [2]; Natural Earth locator geometry

Selected places, not zone or route boundaries. RTS passenger-service target: February 2027, subject to approvals.

THE STUDY QUESTION

What do everyday experiences reveal about integration?

What opportunities and adjustments do people encounter?

How do they make cross-border arrangements work?

Hong Kong-centred exploratory inquiry / selected experiences and published evidence [7–8]

The comparison informs questions for Singapore–Johor; it does not predict the same changes there.

EXISTING RESEARCH AND THIS STUDY

Research describes systems, purchases and patterns of daily activity.

Integration creates opportunities; benefits and adjustment pressures differ. [16]

Systems

Economic, institutional and social integration move at different speeds.

Shen · 2014 publication

Purchases

Different spending mixes across Hong Kong and Mainland China.

Gao, Han & Song · 2025 / data mainly to 2024

Activity patterns

Home, work and other activities cluster differently.

Xiao, Cai & Zhang · 2026 / 2023 data

THIS STUDY ADDS PEOPLE'S ACCOUNTS

Reasons for crossing · choices combined · relationships maintained

Shen (2014) [3]; Gao, Han & Song (2025) [4]; Xiao, Cai & Zhang (2026) [5]; WTO (2024) [16]

Different periods, geographies and methods. General economic context is not an estimate for either city pair.

THE GROUNDWORK

Conversations and visits, read alongside published evidence.

16

Individual and group conversation occasions

Plus visits and background discussions

Studies · statistics · programme documents

Wider AGF sessions inform the closing reflections

3

Shenzhen trips

Futian rail · Lo Wu rail · AGF coach

Hong Kong–Shenzhen Innovation and Technology Park visit

Sheung Shui walk and local chats

Qualitative fieldwork and source records [7–8, 17–18]

Sixteen core conversation occasions, not sixteen people. Wider AGF reflections are separate. Not a representative sample.

AN ADAPTED WAY TO READ THE MATERIAL

Three lenses for the accounts

A **Livelihoods and choices**
Household choices and local business conditions

B **Everyday services and navigation**
Services offered around lives spanning both places

C **Relationships and support**
Connections that continue and opportunities that develop

Institutions run across all three.

Selected themes adapted from Arup / Resilient Cities Network, City Resilience Framework (2024) [6]

Study lenses, not official framework dimensions or a measured city resilience score.

FOUR OVERLAPPING ARRANGEMENTS / 1–2

Users and movers

01 CROSS-BORDER USER





Repair customer

Dining visitors

Based mainly on one side; selected activities across the border

02 NORTHBOUND MOVER



Guide who moved north

Home moves from Hong Kong to Shenzhen

Illustrative accounts [7] / conceptual role illustrations, not interviewee portraits

Arrangements describe behaviour and can overlap. Names are recurring labels; all accounts are paraphrased.

FOUR OVERLAPPING ARRANGEMENTS / 3–4

Work, study and continuing ties

03 CROSS-BORDER WORKER / STUDENT



Schooling illustration

16,139

Daily cross-boundary schoolchildren

2024/25 · official evidence

04 HONG KONG BASE / MAINLAND TIES



Resident with Shenzhen ties

Works & rents in HK

Property, family & friends in Shenzhen

Resident's account [7]; Education Bureau, 2026/27 Estimates, annex table 1 [9]

Schoolchild is a research illustration, not an interviewee. Mainland homes are not necessarily in Shenzhen.

LOCALLY BASED ACCOUNTS / SHEUNG SHUI

The people who remain locally based



Sheung Shui store manager

Fanling home · Sheung Shui work



Sheung Shui resident

Resident near the border



Sheung Shui shop employee

Employee at an estate shop

Three brief Sheung Shui chats and walking observations, 31 October 2026 [8]

Distinct accounts, not a local population sample. Crossing for an activity does not mean moving home or all spending.

LENS A / HOUSEHOLD CHOICES

Shenzhen attracts some activities; Hong Kong routines remain.

REASONS TO CHOOSE SHENZHEN



Repair customer

Parts & expertise

For older equipment



Dining visitors

Choice · space · price

Online options when local shops lack stock



Guide who moved north

Preferred work, lower living costs

Lower earnings too; prepared before moving

REASONS SOME ACTIVITIES STAY LOCAL



Sheung Shui store manager

Meals in SZ; shopping mainly in HK

Visits about monthly



Sheung Shui resident

Crowding limits crossings

Infrequent visits

PARENT'S PERSONAL ACCOUNT · PARAPHRASED

Child's HK activities leave little time; with childcare + half a day, might visit.

Repair customer, dining visitors, guide, parent [7]; Sheung Shui store manager and resident [8]

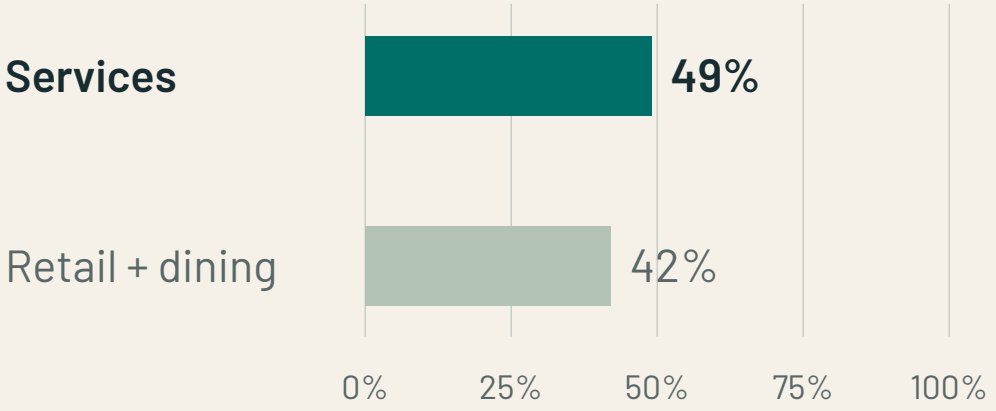
Selected accounts, not fixed household categories. No quotations or measured savings; illustrations identify roles.

LENS A / HOUSEHOLD CHOICES · PUBLISHED EVIDENCE

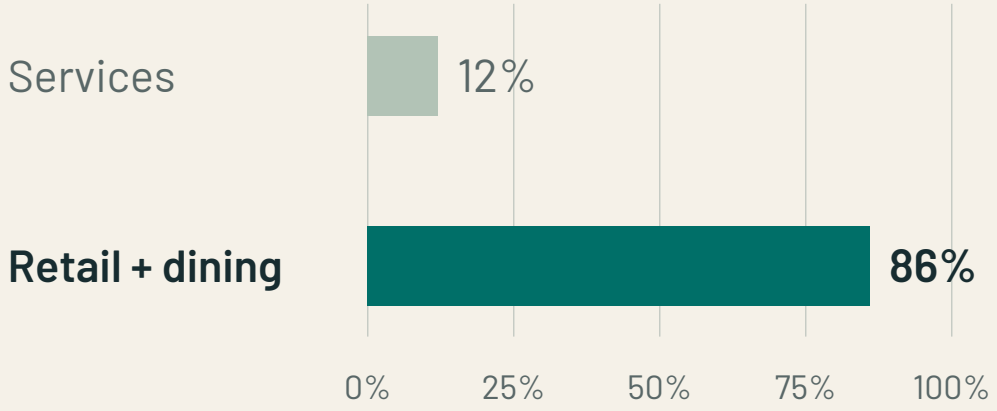
Mainland: services. Hong Kong: retail and dining.

Recorded spending in each location · January–May 2024

MAINLAND CHINA



HONG KONG



? Who uses these services?

Occasional visits, or lives spanning both places? The published breakdown cannot tell us.

Gao, Han & Song, Hong Kong Travelers in Mainland China (March 2025), Section 3.2 / Figure 8 [4]

Selected AlipayHK cross-border spenders; Mainland, not Shenzhen only. Remaining spending omitted. No displacement estimate.

LENS A / LOCAL BUSINESS CONDITIONS

Business exposure differs by customers and occasions.



Guide who moved north

Meal occasion matters

Daily meals near work

vs special-occasion dining



Sheung Shui shop employee

Nearby residents

Estate shop

Few tourists described



Sheung Shui store manager

Locals + Mainland visitors

Landmark North

Busier Monday–Thursday



Fewer crowds, in two accounts

Resident + estate-shop employee

Comparable footfall data still needed

Do chains adapt better?

Familiar chains observed; a question to test, not a survival finding.

Guide's interpretation [7]; Sheung Shui staff/resident accounts and walking observations [8]

Reported customer mixes and perceptions, not measured market shares, restaurant impacts or business survival.

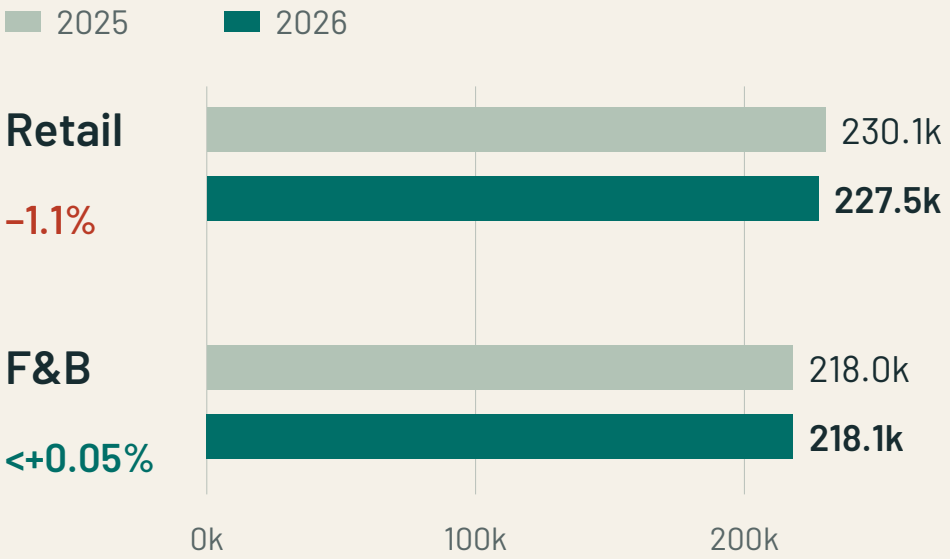
LENS A / LOCAL BUSINESS CONDITIONS · HONG KONG CONTEXT

Employment and spending show different patterns

Professor Shen's interpretation: new businesses may sustain jobs after others close.

PERSONS ENGAGED

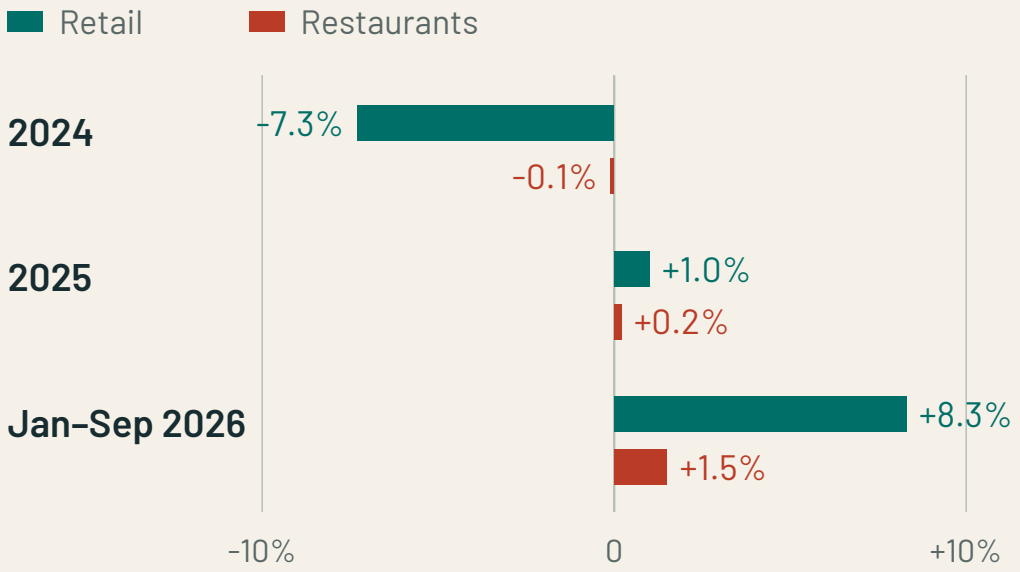
June 2025 and June 2026



Sector totals do not follow workers after closures.

SALES AND RECEIPTS VALUE

Year-on-year change



2026 is provisional year to date, not a full year.

C&SD: persons engaged, June 2026, Table 1 [20]; retail sales [10] and restaurant receipts [19]; Shen discussion [18]

Figures and changes use source rounding. Value, not volume. Citywide trends do not isolate Shenzhen's effect.

LENS A / TAKEAWAY

Cross-border choices are selective; business pressures vary.

Availability and price

Shenzhen offers alternatives for selected experiences and services.

Daily routines

Time and convenience keep some spending in Hong Kong.

Customers and occasions

Competition differs by whom a business serves and when.

Integration can help people combine what each place offers.

Exploratory synthesis of selected accounts, consumption research and retail context [4, 7–8, 10]

No net welfare calculation, representative household gain or causal business-loss estimate.

LENS B / EVERYDAY SERVICES AND NAVIGATION

Services help people manage activities in both places.

FUTIAN ARRIVAL

Immigration staff helped with the arrival form.

Information & referrals



Separate help point at Futian

Cross-border delivery



Visible storefronts in Shenzhen

Licence conversion



Assistance advertised in Sheung Shui

PROPERTY AGENT'S ACCOUNT · PARAPHRASED

Tuition in Shenzhen for Hong Kong-curriculum students.

Futian observation and property-agent account [7]; Sheung Shui visit [8]; photographs supplied by Bob and Jamie

Observed provision and reported offerings are distinct. Licence conversion, not vehicle plates. Use and outcomes not assessed.

LENS B / GOVERNMENT DIRECTION AND AN EXISTING PILOT

Hong Kong is exploring GBA care to ease pressure and shorten waits

POLICY INTENTION · APRIL 2025 [21]

HKU–Shenzhen Hospital follow-up pilot

>5,900

Eligible HA patients joined

By January 2026

HA follow-up appointment → **Corresponding clinic in Shenzhen**

Patients authorise access to records through eHealth.

Return to HA follow-up ← Referral on request, according to clinical need

Health Secretary, LegCo reply, 2 April 2025 [21]; HKSAR Government and Health Bureau, 2026 [12]

Policy intention and programme use, not demonstrated relief of hospital pressure. Eligibility and coverage are scheme-specific.

LENS B / TAKEAWAY

Cross-border needs can also create business activity

Services around cross-border lives

Delivery · tuition · paperwork assistance

→

Potential income and employment

Will an arrangement still work as health, care or mobility needs change?

Public and community support matters alongside commercial services.

Synthesis of observed and reported services [7–8]; healthcare arrangement [12]; Shen discussion [18]

Scale and wider economic contribution remain unmeasured. Commercial provision may not meet every need.

LENS C / CONTINUING CONNECTIONS

Relationships span places

Migration and cross-border marriages have created longstanding ties.

2017: nearly 3 in 10 trips were to visit relatives or friends. [23]

	HONG KONG	SHENZHEN
 **Resident with Shenzhen ties**	Work and rented home	Property, family, friends and a sense of home
 **Guide who moved north**	Family visits	Home, community and guiding friendships

Friends shared a lead to qualify for guiding work.

ANOTHER PERSONAL ACCOUNT · PARAPHRASED

Over ten years in Hong Kong; speaks Cantonese, but does not feel able to call himself a Hongkonger.
Most time goes to work and school-related groups, with little time to join local groups.

Resident and guide accounts [7]; informal lunch conversation, 3 November 2026 [17]; Planning Department [23]

2017 figure: 28.8% of HK–Mainland trips by people living in HK, during a two-week survey. Not people or Shenzhen-only trips.

LENS C / TAKEAWAY

Home, connections and identity need not follow residence

Continuing ties Keep activities and relationships connected to a place.

New contacts Can open opportunities elsewhere.

Language and years of residence leave part of the picture unseen.

Exploratory synthesis of selected accounts [7, 17]

Connections, chosen identity and participation are distinct. No population measure or causal effect is established.

A QUESTION RAISED BY THE THREE LENSES

Can lasting ties sustain participation after a move or change in routine?

A HYPOTHESIS TO INVESTIGATE

Residence, relationships and a sense of home may change in different ways.

Continued spending

Useful referrals

Community participation

Track these separately from where someone lives.

A wider research question arising from the accounts [7]

Stronger ties sustaining participation is a hypothesis, not an effect measured in this study.

QUESTIONS WORTH EXPLORING

Questions for further inquiry

A LIVELIHOODS AND CHOICES

Which businesses can adapt—and which workers need help?

Online competition and market reach

Workers' next jobs and earnings

B EVERYDAY SERVICES

Which needs can support viable businesses?

Demand, use and costs

Where public or community support is needed

C RELATIONSHIPS AND SUPPORT

Do lasting ties sustain participation after a move?

Spending, referrals and contribution

Connections that can continue remotely

Further inquiry prompted by selected accounts and contextual evidence

Research questions, not findings. Measurement details and potential responses remain in the supporting appendices.

SINGAPORE–JOHOR / QUESTIONS TO EXAMINE LOCALLY

Which purchases move, and which ties remain?

Different countries, work/residence rules and service arrangements

For businesses

FORECAST ADDITIONAL ANNUAL SPENDING WITH RTS

SG consumers to JB



S$1.05bn

JB consumers to SG



S$756m

About S$290m net incremental outflow

Ask customers what they would buy or do in JB, and why.

Proposal: HK–SZ learning exchange, then small local tests

For lives across the border

IF TRAVEL BECAME EASIER

Around 1 in 3

Singapore respondents could envisage buying a JB home and retiring there.

Conditional interest · 2024 survey

Continued spending, relationships and participation?

Remote ties · new needs for Johor providers

Johor residents: how do changing demand, jobs, housing and services affect them?

RTS study commissioned by SBF / RAS / SRA, July 2026 [13]; Blackbox SensingSG, February 2024 [14]

Hatched bars = forecasts, not GDP or JS-SEZ effects. Survey interest is not migration. Exchange is a proposal.

WHAT THESE ACCOUNTS HELP US SEE

Everyday choices reveal opportunities and adjustments.

A Shenzhen alternatives create competition; HK routines still anchor spending.

B Cross-border needs create service opportunities, alongside public and community support.

C Relationships sustain connections and open opportunities across cities.

THE WIDER QUESTION

How do lasting ties relate to participation and belonging when life spans cities?

Sources, field photographs and interactive research

BROADER REFLECTIONS / AGF SESSIONS

Ideas I am taking from these conversations

Dee Poon

Holding several identities

Connections and responsibilities can span more than one place.

Benjamin Hung · Standard Chartered

Corporates can set goals and act

A business can chart a pathway through decisions within its influence.

Jockey Club

Inspiration from a redistribution model

Could gains help people who face disproportionate adjustment costs?

What's next? I'm still deciding whether and how to take this further.

Jamie's reflections on wider AGF sessions [22] / separate from the sixteen core conversation occasions

Paraphrases and ideas for consideration, not quotations, commitments or evidence that these responses will work.